Hedgewar designed for the RSS—khaki shirt and shorts, a black khaki cap, long socks and boots—was 'much like' what was worn by Congress volunteers at 'the 1920 Congress session at Nagpur'.[7] Equally, there is a view that the dress code seemed to replicate the British police uniform of the time,[8] just as there is a view that the black caps may have been influenced by the Italian Fascist Benito Mussolini's black caps.[9]

The RSS was banned by the Government of India on 4 February 1948, four days after the assassination of Gandhi, and 17,000 of its members were arrested. The ban was lifted on 12 July 1949.[10] Yet, Gandhi is now so central to the RSS's iconography that Sarsanghchalak Mohan Bhagwat chose to begin his annual Vijayadashami speech with an incantation to Gandhi on his 150th birth anniversary for two years running: in 2018 and 2019.[11]

On the other hand, few leaders have been as influential in defining the RSS as Madhav Sadashiv Golwalkar (often referred to as Guruji), who succeeded Hedgewar as the RSS's second sarsanghchalak on 3 July 1940[12] and oversaw the organisation for three decades. His 1939 book, *We, Our Nationhood Defined*, which came out of his abridged translation of G.D. Savarkar's Marathi work *Rashtra Mimansa* (Nation Worship), was for a long time regarded as a systematic exposition of RSS thinking.[13] Yet, the RSS publicly disowned *We, Or Our Nationhood Defined* in 2006 as 'neither representing the views of Guruji nor of the RSS'.[14]

The 1939 book was, for decades, considered a foundational RSS document, separating Hindus from others. In its pages, Golwalkar argued that India was the holy land for Hindus, that the country needed a 'national regeneration' and this could only come from a revival of the 'great Hindu race' professing its 'illustrious Hindu religion'. Hinduism, for Golwalkar, had been grievously hurt by 'degenerating contact with the debased civilisations of Mussalmans and the Europeans', and the revival of India was inseparable from the revival of Hinduness. As he put it, 'All those not belonging to the national, i.e. Hindu Race, Religion, Culture and Languages, naturally fall out of the pale of real "National" Life.'[15]